

THE FIVEFOLD MURDER AT WALTHAMSTOW.

William Gouldstone's fifth child died on Thursday morning from injuries inflicted upon it by its father. The whole family, therefore, has been killed. On the same day, at the Court House at Stratford, the miserable man, who is 26 years of age, and a blacksmith, was charged with murdering his three children—Charles, aged three years and a half; Herbert, two years and a half; and Frederick, aged sixteen months—by putting them into a water cistern at his residence; also with murdering his two male infant children, seven days old, by striking them on the head with a hammer at the same time and place.

Mrs. Ada Hamilton, wife of William Hamilton, residing in the same house as the prisoner, said—I am a monthly nurse. I have been acting as nurse to prisoner's wife, who was confined on August 1st of twins, both male children. There were three other children in the family—Charles, Herbert, and Frederick. Last night between five and six o'clock I was in Mrs. Gouldstone's bed-room washing the two babies. While doing so the prisoner came in from the street. I heard him go into the kitchen where the two eldest children were playing. Freddy was in the bedroom with me and his mother. When I heard the prisoner come in I went to the kitchen just to see who it was, and I said to him, "Oh, you did frighten me, I wondered who it was." He made no reply. I did not notice anything particular about him. I went back into the bedroom and finished washing the baby, when he came into the room. This was ten minutes after he came indoors. He stood by his wife's bedside, but did not speak to her. She said to him, "How is it you are home so early?" and he replied, "I left the place while the manager had gone to dinner, and I came home." His wife then asked him if he had told them at the shop about her confinement, and he answered, "No." With that he took the little boy Frederick off the bed and into the kitchen. When I had finished washing the first infant I went into the kitchen after I had put the baby by the mother's side. I saw the prisoner sitting on the fireguard, the three children playing on the floor. He had a piece of string in his hand. I asked the prisoner if he had had his tea, and he said, "No." I then told him it was ready for him, and with that went back into the bedroom, and washed the other baby. Having done so, I put it into the bed by the side of the mother, and then returned to the kitchen. I passed into the wash-house beyond, and saw a chair by the cistern. The children were at this time still playing in the kitchen. The cistern was in the wash-house, up high. The prisoner was sitting on the fireguard in the kitchen. A perambulator had stood there, but it had been moved out a bit. I asked who had put it there, and the little boy Charles said, "Daddy did." I took the chair back into the kitchen, and then returned to the bedroom and got Mrs. Gouldstone out of her bed. I remade the bed, and she got into it again. Just at this time, as she was getting into bed, the prisoner came along the passage and looked into the room, I said, "You can come in, Mr. Gouldstone." He made some answer in a mumbling tone, which I could not hear. With that I said to Mrs. Gouldstone, "Shall I leave the room a minute? Perhaps Mr. Gouldstone wants to speak to you," and she answered, "Yes, do, my dear." With that I left the room and went downstairs. I heard the prisoner open the kitchen door, which was shut as I passed it, walk across the landing, and into the bedroom. I got to the yard door when I heard screams of "Murder!" from the prisoner's wife. I ran upstairs and tried to open the door, she still crying "Murder!" inside. I could hear no one speak but her. I heard her saying, "Good God! he is murdering my children." I did not hear the cries of the children. Being unable to open the door I leaned over the bannisters and called out "help!" three or four times. The landlady of the house, whom I had seen in the yard when I was there, ran towards me. We both pushed the door to try to force it open, but could not do so. The prisoner opened the door himself. I had called out to him, "Open the door." His wife was still crying out. When he opened the door I said, "Oh, you wicked man, what have you done?" He said, "I have killed my children. I am a happy man now. Your other three children are in the cistern." He was then speaking to his wife. I then went to his wife's side and saw both babies bleeding from the mouth. There were marks of violence on them. One of the children had a bruise over one of its eyes. I examined the children, and finding they were not dead I at once sent for a medical man. They appeared to be dying. The accused went into the kitchen and I stopped with his wife for a few seconds. Mrs. Gouldstone said to me, "He says he has killed the other three children, go and see, will you?" I went into the kitchen and saw the prisoner coming in the kitchen door from the wash-house with the body of the boy Frederick in his arms, and he laid it on the floor. It was wet. I turned back, and seeing Mrs. Gouldstone coming out of her room along the landing I ran back to her as I did not want her to see the child. It seemed as if it had been in the water, and appeared to be dead. I was very much frightened. I went back to the mother, and I did not leave her for ten minutes. When I went into the kitchen again I saw the three children lying on the ground with a gentleman (a chemist) leaning over them. They were all in a row—side by side. They were swamped with water. He said nothing, and no one spoke to him. I saw a police-constable come afterwards, and saw the accused taken into custody. Prisoner and the policeman went into the bedroom, and his wife asked him to leave all the money he had as she had the doctor to pay. Both the infant children are now dead. One died half-an-hour after the prisoner was taken away, and the other at about two o'clock that morning. While in the room with his wife the prisoner said, "All the children are dead now; I shall be hanged, and you will be single. You wished them dead, and now they are." He then kissed his wife. I have lived in the house for ten weeks, and know that the prisoner has always lived on good terms with his wife; but I noticed he appeared strange after the twins were born. He was not unkind to the children, he seemed fond of them all, but he had not looked at the twins. His wife was now dangerously ill in bed.

The prisoner was remanded till Saturday.

Though the largest of the three Courts was used for the trial of Gouldstone at Stratford on Saturday, scores of people were unable to gain admission, so large was the crowd of spectators. Gouldstone walked with the police from Stratford Railway Station, and was met by a crowd who booed at him until he was got into the Court. At the conclusion of the magisterial proceedings (at which prisoner was further remanded) he was removed by the side entrance and driven off in a cab.